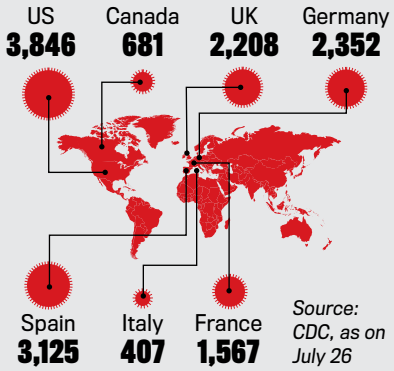
Mathew. With the global outbreak, however, a slightly different progression is being reported—many of those infected do not have flu-like symptoms and get only one or two open sores or pus-filled blisters near their genitals. "There is still much to learn about how the virus will behave outside its endemic zone," says Dr Sushila Kataria, senior director of internal medicine at Medanta - The Medicity, Gurgaon.

symptoms of infection need to be isolated and a doctor informed at the earliest. "We have to wear a face mask, wash hands frequently and maintain social distancing to prevent transmission," says Dr Suresh Kumar, director of LNJP Hospital, Delhi, which is treating Delhi's first and so far only case of monkeypox. A self-limiting disease, the symptoms typically last 2-4 weeks and treatment is generally

TRACING THE THREAT

MORE THAN 16,000 CASES IN 75 COUNTRIES

Countries with highest number of cases



Source: CDC, as on July 26

WHAT INDIA IS DOING

- Four confirmed cases in India (3 in Kerala, 1 in Delhi) and a suspected case in Telangana
- States advised to focus on contact tracing and symptom surveillance
- Hospitals are being identified in each state for quarantining those suspected of infection
- All international arrivals being screened for symptoms
- 15 labs set up to support NIV, Pune, in testing for the virus
- Contacts of all 3 cases in Kerala have been traced and are in quarantine
- Contact tracing for the Delhi case is ongoing

Graphic by **TANMOY CHAKRABORTY**

Spreading primarily through large respiratory droplets, the virus can also be transmitted through direct contact with body fluids or lesion material, and indirect contact with lesion material, such as through contaminated clothing or linen. The virus has been found in semen and can spread through sex with an infected person. Though many of the cases in Europe have been among homosexual men, the WHO has since stated that the virus can infect anyone.

While it is not as contagious as Covid-19, doctors say similar steps are needed to stay safe from monkeypox—good hygiene, avoiding crowded or poorly ventilated spaces, and keeping away from those who have travelled abroad recently. Those who show

THE CURRENT FOCUS IS ON SURVEILLANCE OF INTERNATIONAL ARRIVALS AND CONTACT TRACING TO STOP THE VIRUS FROM SPREADING

symptomatic. As per the WHO guidelines, the antiviral approved to treat smallpox (tecovirimat) can be used to treat monkeypox if it turns severe in those with weakened immune systems. Mortality has been low so far, with five deaths reported in non-endemic countries in 2022. "It is a painful disease, though, and can impair quality of life and productivity. So it shouldn't be taken lightly," says Dr Kataria.

According to the US-based Centers for Disease Control and Prevention (CDC), the smallpox vaccine is at least 85 per cent effective in preventing monkeypox due to close links between the two viruses. In India, after smallpox was eradicated in 1979, its vaccine was dropped from the mandatory vaccination programme. Some reports suggest that the disease is less severe in those above 40 as they would have received the smallpox vaccine. However, Dr Kang observes that vaccine protection wanes with age and more data needs to be gathered before concluding that those who have had the smallpox vaccine are immune to monkeypox as well.

For those who want to take the vaccine today, it will be a tough challenge. After the global eradication of smallpox in 1980, the live virus was preserved for research at only two locations—the CDC in Atlanta, US, and the State Research Center of Virology and Biotechnology in Koltsovo, Russia. And Denmark-based Bavarian Nordic is the only company that produces a smallpox vaccine, which the European Union in July allowed to be marketed as a protective measure against monkeypox. European countries, according to the WHO, are currently at the highest risk.

In India, there are currently no plans to procure the vaccine or to make it mandatory. Such plans may be made later depending on how the infection spreads, says a health ministry official, who does not wish to be named. As of now, the focus is on surveillance of international arrivals and contact tracing to stop the disease from spreading.

"The situation is under control and health authorities are on high alert," says NITI Aayog member Dr V.K. Paul. "Mandatory screening is being done at international airports, and 15 laboratories have been set up for testing support." The Union health ministry has sent out treatment and surveillance protocols to all states. It has advised that a hospital be identified for quarantining and treating those suspected of